The Prescott Girls – Teacher Guide

Using *The Prescott Girls* in the Classroom

About the Book

The Prescott Girls is a middle-grade historical novel inspired by real nineteenth-century needlework samplers created by the Prescott family of Dresden, Maine. The story follows three sisters—Beckie, Louisa, and Sallie—as their lives change after the death of their father and their move to the Old Pownalborough Court House.

Through their experiences, readers explore daily life in Maine during the 1830s, including family life, education, travel, and the ways ideas and news spread between communities.

The story combines documented historical details with imaginative storytelling to help readers better understand how children and families may have lived during this period.

Recommended Grade Levels

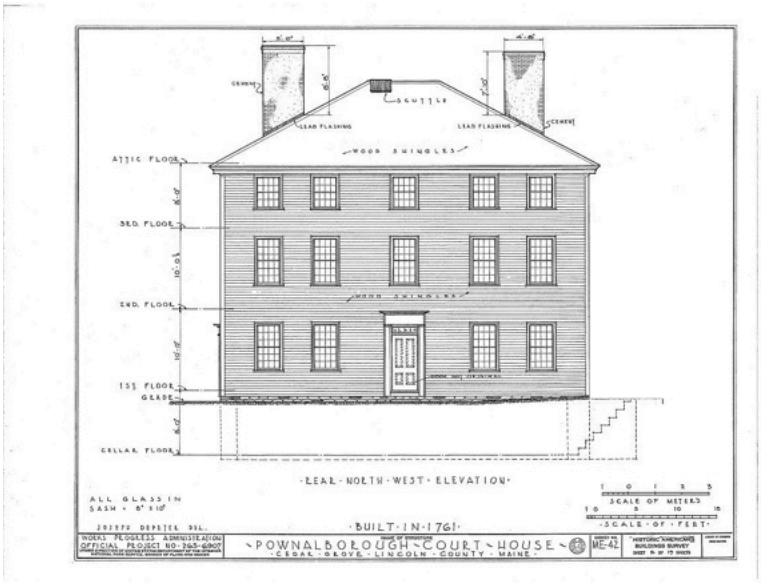
The Prescott Girls is well suited for:

- Grades 4–7
- Middle-grade literature units
- American history units covering the early nineteenth century
- Homeschool literature and history studies

The book can be used as a **read-aloud**, an **independent reading selection**, or part of a **cross-curricular history unit**.

Subjects and Themes

Teachers may connect the book to several subject areas:



History

- daily life in early nineteenth-century America
- small-town life in Maine
- early reform movements such as abolition

Literacy

- historical fiction
- character development
- letter writing and communication

Social Studies

- geography of Maine
- family structures and community life
- trade and transportation

Art and Material Culture

- needlework and samplers
- historical clothing and household objects
- illustration and visual storytelling

Using the Study Guides

The downloadable study guides are designed to support classroom discussion and historical exploration connected to the story.

Teachers may use them individually or combine several guides into a larger unit.

Examples include:

Exploring Daily Life

- Life in 1830s Maine
- Letters and Communication in the 1830s
- Geography of *The Prescott Girls*

Understanding Historical Artifacts

- Beckie’s Sampler
- How Historians Trace Artifacts
- Family Trees

Social and Cultural Context

- Needlework and Girls’ Education in Early America
- The Sugar Boycott

Creative and Visual Exploration

- Creating the Illustrations
- Printable Maine Map (1833)

Suggested Classroom Activities

Teachers may encourage students to:

- write letters as if they lived in the 1830s
- create their own sampler designs using alphabet patterns
- draw illustrations for scenes from the story
- map the Prescott family’s journey across Maine
- compare daily life in the 1830s with life today

These activities help students connect historical information with the experiences of the characters.

Historical Imagination

The story is based on documented historical objects and research connected to the Prescott family and the Old Pownalborough Court House.

Like many historical novels, it combines **evidence from the past with imaginative storytelling**. This approach allows readers to explore how people may have lived while recognizing that not every detail can be known with certainty.

Historical fiction can help students think about the past not only as a set of facts but as the lived experiences of real families and communities.

Questions for Reflection

Teachers may encourage students to consider:

1. How does the setting influence the lives of the Prescott sisters?
2. What challenges might families face when starting a new life in a different place?
3. How do letters and conversations help ideas spread between communities?
4. What details in the story help readers imagine life in the 1830s?
5. Why might historians study objects like samplers to understand the past?

Extending the Learning

Students who are interested in exploring further may investigate:

• local history in their own communities
• historical crafts such as embroidery or weaving
• the development of the postal system
• how historians use artifacts to learn about everyday life

These activities encourage students to think about how history can be discovered through objects, places, and stories.